

MINTBROOKS

The Credit Sequence: A Step- by-Step Workbook for Rebuilding Your Score When You've Already Tried Everything

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Before We Start

I avoided looking at my credit score for two years.

Not because I forgot about it. Because every time I even thought about logging in to check, I felt this dull, heavy dread settle in — the kind that lives in your chest and makes you suddenly very interested in something else. Dishes. A show I wasn't even watching. Anything.

Here's what I eventually figured out: I wasn't avoiding the number. I was avoiding the story the number told me about myself. That I was bad at this. That I'd messed up. That responsible adults don't end up here.

That story is a lie. And it's a lie that keeps you frozen.

This workbook isn't about motivation. I'm not going to tell you that you deserve financial freedom or that you just need to believe in yourself. I'm going to tell you what I wish someone had told me: **the reason your credit score hasn't moved isn't your character. It's the order you've been doing things.**

Credit bureaus respond to sequence. Most people try to fix everything at once — dispute errors, pay off debt, open a secured card, reduce utilization — simultaneously, in the wrong order, and then get disappointed when the score barely budes. Or worse, drops.

What I'm going to give you is the specific sequence. The order of operations that produces the fastest, most reliable score movement given where you're starting from.

It is not magic. It will take months, not days. But if you do these steps in this order, the score will move. I've watched it work. I watched it work for me.

Let's get into it.

How to Use This Workbook

Each chapter has:

- **The concept** — what's actually happening in the system
- **The action** — what you do this week
- **The worksheet** — where you write it down

Write in this. Make it messy. The act of writing forces clarity in a way that reading alone doesn't.

You'll need:

- Your credit reports from all three bureaus (free at AnnualCreditReport.com)
- A notebook or the margins of this document
- About 30 minutes per chapter

Chapter 1: Pull the Report — The Full Picture

THE CONCEPT

The first thing most people do when they want to fix their credit is check their score on Credit Karma and feel bad about it. The score is almost useless at this stage. What matters is the **report** — because the report tells you what's actually dragging the score down.

There are three credit bureaus: Equifax, Experian, TransUnion. Each one gets slightly different information from creditors. Your score at each bureau is different. The items on your report at each bureau are sometimes different. A collection account might appear on one bureau but not the others. This matters because when you take action, you're taking action on a specific bureau — and targeting the wrong one wastes time.

Pull all three reports at AnnualCreditReport.com. This is the only site federally authorized to give you free reports. It does not charge you. It does not try to upsell you. Every other "free credit report" site is trying to get you to sign up for a monitoring service.

THE SURPRISING THING NOBODY TELLS YOU

Checking your own credit report does **not** hurt your score. It never has. That's a myth that has kept people from pulling the information they need. When you check your own score, it's called a "soft inquiry." When a lender checks it, that's a "hard inquiry." Only hard inquiries affect your score, and only by a few points, and only for 12 months.

You can check your own credit every single day and it will not move your score one point in either direction.

THE ACTION

1. Go to AnnualCreditReport.com
2. Pull all three reports (Equifax, Experian, TransUnion)
3. Download or print each one
4. On the worksheet below, list every negative item on each report

WORKSHEET 1: THE FULL PICTURE

Instructions: Go through each report and fill in the table. Be thorough — write down everything with a negative flag, late payment, or collection status.

ITEM	CREDITOR NAME	BUREAU(S) IT APPEARS ON	BALANCE	DATE OF FIRST DELINQUENCY	STATUS (COLLECTION / LATE / CHARGED- OFF)
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					

My current scores:

- Equifax:

- Experian:

- TransUnion:

- Date I pulled these:

My current open credit accounts (active, in good standing):

ACCOUNT	CREDIT LIMIT	CURRENT BALANCE	UTILIZATION % (BALANCE ÷ LIMIT × 100)

Total available credit: \$

Total current balances: \$

Overall utilization: __%

Chapter 2: Utilization First — The Lever Nobody Uses Correctly

THE CONCEPT

If you have any open credit cards with balances on them, this is almost certainly the fastest lever available to you right now.

Credit utilization — the percentage of your available credit that you're using — makes up roughly 30% of your FICO score. And unlike late payments, which sit on your report for seven years, utilization is **recalculated every single month** when your card issuers report your balance to the bureaus.

This means: if you reduce your utilization this month, your score reflects it next month. There is no waiting period. No aging. No dispute process. Just the math.

The thresholds that matter:

- **Under 30%** — this is the number most people hear
- **Under 10%** — this is where scores jump meaningfully
- **1%** — this is the secret threshold almost nobody talks about

Zero utilization (paying off everything and carrying no balance) actually scores **slightly worse** than 1% utilization. The bureau algorithm interprets zero utilization as inactivity. Carry one dollar on one card. Not zero. One dollar.

THE SEQUENCE RULE

Before you do anything else — before you dispute, before you open a new card, before you contact a collection agency — you reduce utilization on every open card to under 10% if at all possible.

Here is why: every other action you take will have more impact on a score that already reflects low utilization. Disputing an error on a report where your utilization is at 87% will yield a different result than disputing the same error with utilization at 8%. The bureau's algorithm is multiplicative, not additive. Your starting utilization is the baseline that every other factor is applied against.

THE ACTION THIS WEEK

1. List every open credit card and its current balance (you did this in Worksheet 1)
2. Calculate utilization on each card individually (not just overall — individual card utilization also matters)
3. Identify which cards are above 30% and which are above 10%
4. Make a paydown plan targeting the highest-utilization card first — even if it's not the highest balance
5. If you cannot pay down right now, read the "When You Can't Pay" section below

WHEN YOU CAN'T PAY DOWN RIGHT NOW

Two zero-cost strategies:

Request a credit limit increase. Call your card issuer and ask for a credit limit increase without taking a cash advance. Many issuers will increase limits with no hard inquiry if you've had the account more than 12 months and haven't missed payments. A \$500 increase on a \$1,500 limit card with a \$900 balance moves your utilization on that card from 60% to 45%. Not perfect, but meaningful.

Ask to be added as an authorized user. If you have a family member or close friend with a card that has low utilization and a long account history, ask them to add you as an authorized user. You don't need to use the card. You don't even need to hold it. Their account history and low utilization will appear on your report and lift your score.

WORKSHEET 2: UTILIZATION ACTION PLAN

Per-card utilization:

CARD	LIMIT	BALANCE	UTILIZATION %	PRIORITY (CIRCLE)
				High / Medium / Low
				High / Medium / Low
				High / Medium / Low
				High / Medium / Low

My paydown target (first card to attack):

Amount I can put toward this per month: \$

Estimated months to get under 10% on this card:

Credit limit increase candidates (cards I'll call this week):

1.

2.

Authorized user opportunity:

Person:

Card (rough idea):

Will I ask them? (circle) YES / NOT YET

Chapter 3: Address the Collections — In the Right Order

THE CONCEPT

Collections are terrifying to deal with. I know. But the good news is that you have more power here than any collection agency wants you to know about.

The first thing to understand: **not all collections are equal**. There are three types, and they require completely different approaches.

Type 1: The error. Something is on your report that shouldn't be. Wrong balance. Wrong account. A debt that was already paid. A debt that isn't yours. These get disputed directly with the bureau — and under the Fair Credit Reporting Act, the bureau has 30 days to verify or remove it.

Type 2: The legitimate, but old, collection. The debt is real. You owe it. But the statute of limitations on debt collection in your state may have expired (typically 3-7 years depending on state and debt type). If the debt is old enough, it may be "zombie debt" — still on your report hurting your score, but legally uncollectable.

Type 3: The legitimate, recent, active collection. This is the one that requires a real decision.

THE CRITICAL THING ABOUT PAYING COLLECTIONS

Here is where most people make a costly mistake: they pay a collection account without getting anything in writing first.

When you pay a collection, there are two possible outcomes:

- The collection agency updates the account status to "paid" — which still appears on your report as a collection for up to seven years from the date of first delinquency.

This does **not reliably raise your score** in older FICO models.

- The collection agency agrees to a **Pay-For-Delete** — they remove the item entirely from your report in exchange for payment.

Pay-for-delete is your goal. It is legal. It is negotiable. Many collection agencies will agree to it, especially for older accounts or smaller balances. You need it in writing before you send a dollar.

The sequence: dispute errors first. Then address zombie debt. Then negotiate pay-for-delete on legitimate collections. Then pay.

THE CREDIT CARD THAT DOESN'T REQUIRE CREDIT

One of the most asked questions I get: what do you do if you need a credit card right now but can't get approved for anything?

Here's what I'd do if I were starting from scratch: look into Yendo. It's a card that uses your car as collateral instead of your credit score — so there's no credit check. You get a real Visa card, you make purchases, you pay it back, and the payment history gets reported to the bureaus just like any other credit card. It's a way to start building positive payment history without being trapped by a low starting score. The interest rate isn't the best, so you'd want to pay it off monthly if possible — but as a credit-building tool while everything else in this sequence is playing out, it's genuinely useful. Find it at Yendo.com.

WORKSHEET 3: COLLECTION TRIAGE

For each collection on your report:

COLLECTION	AMOUNT	AGE (YEARS SINCE FIRST DELINQUENCY)	ERROR? (Y/N)	ACTION
				Dispute / Pay-for-Delete Negotiate / Research Zombie Status / Leave (near 7yr drop)

Dispute Letter Tracker:

BUREAU	ITEM DISPUTED	DATE SENT	RESPONSE DUE	OUTCOME

Pay-for-Delete Negotiation Log:

COLLECTOR	OFFER MADE	WRITTEN CONFIRMATION RECEIVED?	PAYMENT SENT	ITEM REMOVED?
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Chapter 4: The Debt Stack — Getting Out From Under

THE CONCEPT

I want to talk about credit card debt specifically, because it's the category that traps the most people in this audience.

If you have debt spread across multiple cards or personal loans, you've probably heard of two methods: the avalanche (pay highest interest first) and the snowball (pay smallest balance first). Both are correct in different ways. The avalanche saves the most money mathematically. The snowball wins psychologically because the quick wins keep you going.

I'm not going to tell you which to use. What I am going to tell you is that neither method matters if you can't get the interest rates down first.

THE DEBT CONSOLIDATION OPTION

If you're carrying high-interest debt across multiple accounts — credit cards at 24-28% APR is common — consolidation into a single personal loan at a lower rate can dramatically reduce how much of your monthly payment actually goes to interest vs. principal.

For people in the credit range this workbook is designed for (550-650), personal loan options still exist — they're just harder to find. SlamDunk Finance is a loan matching service worth looking at. You submit your info once and they surface loan options from multiple lenders based on your actual credit profile. It's not a guarantee, but it's a real alternative to calling banks one by one and taking a hard inquiry hit each time. You can look at your options at SlamDunkFinance.com.

If consolidation isn't available to you right now, that's okay. Run the avalanche method, put every extra dollar toward the highest-APR card, and revisit consolidation options in 6 months when the credit sequence work has lifted your score into a more approachable range.

WORKSHEET 4: DEBT STACK MAP

List all debt accounts:

ACCOUNT	BALANCE	INTEREST RATE (APR)	MINIMUM PAYMENT	EXTRA I CAN PAY	METHOD TARGET (CIRCLE)
					Avalanche / Snowball
					Avalanche / Snowball
					Avalanche / Snowball
					Avalanche / Snowball

Total debt: \$

Total minimum payments: \$

Extra I can allocate per month: \$

Estimated payoff time at current rate: _____ months

Consolidation check:

- Have I looked at my consolidation options? (circle) YES / NOT YET
 - Estimated interest savings if I could consolidate at __% : \$___/month
-
-

Chapter 5: The Score Rebuild Timeline

THE CONCEPT

Here is an honest timeline. Not optimistic, not pessimistic. Real.

Month 1-2: Utilization drops. Score starts reflecting this. Expect +15 to +40 points depending on how high your starting utilization was.

Month 2-3: Disputes clear. Errors removed. Depending on what gets removed, this varies enormously — a \$0 improvement (nothing erroneous) to +50-80 points for a removed collection.

Month 3-6: Positive payment history accumulates on any new accounts opened (secured card, Yendo, etc.). This is slow but compounding.

Month 6-12: Account age starts to matter more. Scores in the 580-620 range start pushing toward 650+. Consolidation options improve. Some rewards cards become accessible.

Month 12-24: If no new derogatory items, negative items age and lose scoring weight. Collections from 3+ years ago have significantly less impact than they did at origination.

The most important thing you can do right now: **stop adding new derogatory items.** Every other action in this workbook is working forward. New missed payments are working backward. If you are currently in a position where you cannot cover your minimum payments, that is the first problem to solve — before anything else in this sequence.

WORKSHEET 5: 6-MONTH SCORE PROJECTION

Starting point (from Worksheet 1):

- Lowest score across three bureaus:

- Date:

Expected gains by lever:

- Utilization reduction (estimate): +_ *points*
- *Error disputes (estimate)*: +_ *points*
- Pay-for-delete on collections (estimate): +_ *points*
- *New positive payment history (estimate)*: +_ *points*

Projected score in 6 months:

Target score (what I need for my goal):

My goal (apartment / car / loan / job):

WORKSHEET 6: WEEKLY ACCOUNTABILITY CHECK

Use this once a week. Five minutes. It keeps the sequence moving.

Week of: __

1. Did I make minimum payments on all accounts this week? (Y/N)

2. Did I pay anything extra toward my target card? (Y/N) _____ Amount: \$

3. Did I take any action on a dispute or collection? (Y/N) _____ What:

4. Did I open or inquire about any new credit? (Y/N) _____ Was it necessary?

5. One thing I will do this week that I didn't last week:

The Last Page

I want to say something before you close this.

The shame is the thing that kills progress more than any collection account.

Every week you don't look at the report is another week the sequence can't start. Every time you decide the problem is too big to fix today is another month of compounding delay. The math of credit is actually more forgiving than most people think. The psychology of it — the avoidance, the dread, the "what's the point" — that's the real problem.

You pulled this workbook. You read this far. That means you're already past the hardest part, which was deciding to look at the thing.

The score will move. Keep the sequence.

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